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Symbolic boundaries and musical tastes in Spanish consumers: beyond cultural omnivorousness

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Abstract

This article examines the existence of symbolic boundaries in musical consumption by analyzing patterns of musical tastes among consumers in Spain. To assess the validity of the cultural omnivorousness thesis and its implications for cultural hierarchies, we apply Correlational Class Analysis to identify relational structures of musical tastes and explore how symbolic-cultural boundaries emerge through oppositions between musical genres. Using data from the Survey of Cultural Habits and Practices in Spain (n = 14,524), four distinct musical taste structures are identified. The results reveal heterogeneous configurations of musical preferences characterized by different degrees of breadth, specialization and exclusion. Rather than supporting the idea of a dominant omnivorous pattern, the findings show the persistence of symbolic boundaries expressed through the rejection of specific genres and the coexistence of weak omnivorous and univorous taste structures. Finally, the article discusses the social characteristics associated with these taste configurations and their implications for understanding cultural boundaries in contemporary musical consumption.

Keywords: symbolic cultural boundaries, cultural omnivorousness, CCA - Correlational Class Analysis, cultural consumption, musical taste

Introduction

The social configuration of tastes and its relationship with cultural consumption has occupied a central place in the sociology of culture since the late twentieth century. A key debate contrasts theories linking social structures with tastes and consumption practices (Bourdieu, 1979) and those emphasising the near-unrestricted expansion of tastes among certain social groups, the so-called omnivorous consumers (Peterson, 1992; Peterson & Kern, 1996). The omnivorous thesis has significant sociological implications, including the permeability of socio-symbolic boundaries and the blurring of the cultural hierarchy that dominated consumption under Fordist capitalism. The classical distinction between high and low culture becomes attenuated, as consumers in higher social positions combine traditionally legitimised culture with popular or commercial forms (DiMaggio, 1987; Firat & Venkatesh, 1995; Jameson, 1984). Nevertheless, empirical findings on omnivorousness are mixed and inconsistent (Atkinson, 2011; Nault, Baumann, Childress, & Rawlings, 2021; Veenstra, 2015), and recent critiques have highlighted analytical and methodological challenges in the model (Fernández-Rodríguez & Heikkilä, 2011; Hazir & Warde, 2015; Robette & Roueff, 2014).

In light of this problem, this article examines how symbolic boundaries are structured within musical tastes by analysing relational patterns of musical preferences among consumers in Spain. With this objective, we seek to evaluate the scope of the omnivorous hypothesis, following some recent works. The Spanish case is particularly relevant for two reasons. Historically, its consumption model reflects fragmentation, inequality, and traditional values less focused on the symbolic value of culture, making it less directly comparable to models such as Bourdieu's (Alonso & Fernández Rodríguez, 2020; Bourdieu, 1979). At the same time, Spain differs from more egalitarian Nordic contexts, although cultural patterns are increasingly aligning with those of other Western countries (Janssen, Kristensen, & Verboord, 2025; Lizardo, 2005). Moreover, gaps remain regarding the validity of the omnivorous pattern and the main explanatory variables of consumption, which this study seeks to address.

Theoretical framework: cultural consumption and socio-symbolic boundaries

The Transformation of Symbolic Boundaries: The End of Cultural Hierarchy?

The literature on cultural consumption has extensively explored a central question in sociology: social and symbolic boundaries (Lamont & Molnár, 2002). Although not always explicitly the main focus, the analysis of consumption habits and cultural practices has sparked a debate on the permeability of these boundaries: are there taste structures and cultural preferences free from social discrimination, as suggested by some theses on omnivorous or eclectic consumers?

Bourdieu (1979) is perhaps the scholar who most clearly highlighted the existence of strong symbolic boundaries and their impact on social reproduction (Johnston, Baumann, & Oleschuk, 2019). His thesis on the homology between social structure and tastes posits that inequalities are reflected in rigid symbolic barriers. According to Lamont and Molnár (2002) and Jarness (2015), these boundaries are collectively developed categorizations used to classify and evaluate objects, people, or groups. In *Distinction* (1979), Bourdieu shows how taste structures and lifestyles maintain hierarchical relationships. Upper classes focus on legitimised culture, whereas working classes orient towards popular culture, considered symbolically illegitimate. Intermediate classes develop pretentious tastes, attempting to distinguish themselves while approaching upper classes, though incompletely (Bourdieu & De Saint Martin, 1976).

Years later, based on new data, Peterson and his collaborators proposed the thesis of cultural omnivorousness (Peterson & Kern, 1996; Peterson & Simkus, 1992). The omnivorous consumer follows a broad pattern of cultural consumption that crosses traditional symbolic boundaries, weakening them. By highlighting the absence of a clear social consensus regarding these boundaries, the omnivorous consumer consumes "everything," disregarding distinctions between legitimate and non-legitimate, refined and vulgar tastes.

Omnivorous consumers are often seen as open, tolerant, and inclusive, though some authors caution against an uncritical view (Ferrant, 2018; Florida, 2012; Heikkilä, Hoola, Zdravkovic, & Lamberti, 2025; Peterson & Kern, 1996). This implies, potentially, the weakening or disappearance of symbolic hierarchies in cultural tastes and practices (Lindblom, 2022). The omnivorous pattern has been widely replicated across studies in Europe and the United States (Atkinson, 2011; Chan & Goldthorpe, 2007; Lizardo, 2006; Peterson, 2005; Van Eijck, 2001; Voronin, 2024). In France, studies on "eclectic" consumers highlight a similar capacity to mix cultural products that Bourdieu (1979) had described as separated by irreconcilable symbolic barriers (Coulangeon, 2005, 2017; Donnat, 2004).

In Spain, López-Sintas and García Álvarez (2002) found omnivorous patterns, particularly among highly educated and higher socioeconomic groups. Later works suggest, however, that these patterns are relatively rare (Ariño, 2010; Ariño & Llopis-Goig, 2017; Herrera-Usagre, 2013) and point to the importance of age, social origin, and cultural capital in shaping tastes (Ariño & Llopis-Goig, 2021; Herrera-Usagre, 2021).

Across the literature, two positions have emerged. Veenstra (2015) and Warde et al. (2007), building on Bryson (1996), distinguish between "volume" omnivorism -greater engagement with cultural practices- and "composition" omnivorism -crossing symbolic boundaries in tastes. Recent research refines this distinction to reconcile volume and

composition through “exclusions” (de Vries & Reeves, 2022). A “weak” interpretation allows for some exclusions, with symbolic boundaries limiting preferences (Atkinson, 2011; Hanquinet, 2017; Leguina, Widdop, & Tampubolon, 2016; Nault et al., 2021). A “strong” interpretation describes indiscriminate consumption across lowbrow and highbrow tastes, with few exclusions, suggesting that traditional elitist and class-based distinctions are no longer relevant (de Vries & Reeves, 2022; García-Álvarez, Katz-Gerro, & López-Sintas, 2007). However, recent studies provide evidence contradicting this view (Nault et al., 2021).

These contributions indicate that the persistence of symbolic and cultural boundaries can often be detected by examining dislikes—cultural expressions that provoke opposition, rejection, or disinterest (Merrill, Frieler, & Ackermann, 2023). Warde (2011) emphasized that analyzing what is disliked, whether actively rejected or passively ignored, is crucial for understanding symbolic boundaries. While some studies have considered both likes and dislikes (de Vries & Reeves, 2022; Goldberg, 2011; Lizardo, 2005; Merrill et al., 2023; Veenstra, 2015), this approach has not been systematically applied to cultural consumption studies, particularly in Spain (Robette & Roueff, 2014). We incorporate this strategy in part of our empirical work.

The social genesis of cultural tastes and consumption

From the perspective of factors explaining cultural tastes and consumption, theories differ in how they link social boundaries—unequal access to resources and opportunities—with symbolic boundaries in the cultural field. For Bourdieu (1979), dispositions associated with social position and differences in cultural capital delimit symbolic boundaries, reflected in hierarchical tastes. The omnivore thesis, by contrast, associates middle and upper-middle positions with breadth of taste, thereby weakening symbolic barriers (Chan, 2019; Coulangeon, 2005, 2017; Peterson, 2005; Peterson & Kern, 1996).

Various studies identify omnivorous patterns not only among highly educated or occupationally advantaged groups, but also among young people and women (Chan & Goldthorpe, 2007; Lizardo, 2006; Van Eijck, 2001). Nevertheless, privileged classes remain best positioned to assert their capital and embody dominant values (Lizardo & Skiles, 2015). If the axis of symbolic status has shifted from elitism to the combinatory capacities of tastes, prestige depends on the development of these capacities in fragmented cultural contexts (Chan, 2019; Coulangeon, 2017).

Building on this debate, cultural capital remains a central analytical category for understanding inequalities in cultural consumption practices. Although forms of distinction have been reconfigured around broader and more combinatorial repertoires, as well as logics and judgements such as authenticity (Hahl et al., 2017; Prieur & Savage, 2013), these capacities are not equally distributed across social groups. In this sense, the analysis of cultural capital, both objectified and institutionalised (educational

level), helps explain how patterns of taste, far from being merely individual or open, continue to be structured by socially unequal resources.

Within the cultural field, social consensuses regarding symbolic-cultural differences and hierarchies are changing (de Vries & Reeves, 2022; Goldberg, 2011). Understanding these shifts and the dissensions around socio-symbolic boundaries remains one of the principal challenges in the debate on cultural consumption.

Methodological approach

This article examines symbolic boundaries through the analysis of musical tastes in Spain and explores how these boundaries relate to the social characteristics of consumers. To this end, we apply Correlational Class Analysis (CCA), a method proposed by Goldberg (2011) and further developed by Boutyline (2017), which identifies groups of respondents who share similar relational patterns between preferences.

CCA classifies individuals according to the similarity of the associations they establish between musical genres, rather than the volume of their consumption. In this study, respondents are grouped into different musical taste structures based on the relational configuration of their musical preferences. This approach allows us to identify shared cultural schemas and to capture both affinities and oppositions between genres. In particular, the analysis of positive and negative correlations enables the detection of symbolic boundaries, understood as patterns of rejection or distancing between musical genres.

To examine how these taste structures relate to social characteristics, multiple linear regression models are estimated separately within each CCA group. In each model, musical genres are treated as dependent variables, while the independent variables include socio-demographic characteristics (age, sex, and education level) and indicators of cultural capital, specifically parental cultural practices and respondents' cultural practices during childhood.

This strategy allows us to identify which social factors are associated with preferences or rejections for specific musical genres within each taste structure, and to assess how these associations vary across different configurations of musical tastes.

Data

The analyzed data is derived from the Survey on Cultural Habits and Practices in Spain (EHPCE) in its 2021-22 edition. This survey, conducted by the Ministry of Culture and Sports in collaboration with the National Institute of Statistics, follows the guidelines established by the Cultural Statistics Working Group of EUROSTAT. The survey targets individuals aged 15 and above residing in Spain, with the aim of assessing the evolution of key indicators related to cultural habits and practices, as well as delving into other relevant aspects associated with cultural consumption.

Measures

Musical tastes

Musical tastes were measured using a survey item asking respondents which musical genres they had listened to during the previous quarter, including music accessed through purchases, digital platforms, or downloads. Respondents could select multiple options from a list of 21 musical genres. Given the large number of genres and the binary nature of the variable, an exploratory factor analysis (principal component analysis with Varimax rotation) was conducted to reduce dimensionality. The Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin measure indicated good sampling adequacy (KMO = 0.803), and the analysis yielded a six-factor solution explaining 62.02% of the total variance (Table 1).

Table 1. Rotated component matrix of the exploratory factor analysis

	Component					
	1	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
Author	.020	.093	.081	.114	.107	**.866**
Melodic	-.004	.032	.021	.212	.074	**.859**
Flamenco	.078	.035	.036	**.794**	.084	.133
New flamenco	.140	.126	.084	**.801**	.020	.039
Spanish folk	.043	.062	.199	**.580**	.024	.145
Spanish pop	.089	**.827**	.041	.091	.011	.099
Latin pop	.186	**.748**	.010	.206	-.022	.032
Non-Spanish pop	.156	**.804**	.162	-.048	.026	.004
Blues Soul	.144	.121	**.817**	.139	.098	.071
Jazz	.166	.069	**.822**	.101	.143	.048
World music	.361	.032	**.578**	.139	.048	.005
Reggae	**.598**	.066	.246	.212	.015	-.009
Rap Hip-Hop	**.741**	.062	.079	.129	-.013	-.043
Electronic. techno	**.773**	.117	.053	.043	.021	-.003
Hard rock. metal. punk	**.616**	.074	.184	.002	.046	.000
Dance House	**.666**	.162	.066	-.021	.078	.091
Classical	.049	.032	.269	-.080	**.574**	.252
Opera	.038	.014	.106	.038	**.838**	.035
Zarzuela	.044	-.022	-.026	.144	**.803**	-.006
Explained variance	**13.7%**	**10.5%**	**10.3%**	**9.8%**	**9.2%**	**8.5%**

Extraction method: principal component analysis.
Rotation method: Varimax with Kaiser normalization.
a. The rotation has converged in 6 iterations.
Note: Author & Melodic Music corresponds to the original EHPCE categories *canción de autor* and *canción melódica*, illustrated in the questionnaire with examples such as Serrat and Julio Iglesias, respectively.
Source: author's own elaboration

The rotated component matrix shows the loadings of each genre on the six factors, allowing the identification of coherent groupings of musical preferences. Based on these loadings, the factors were interpreted and labelled as follows: (1) Modern & Urban Music, (2) Pop/Rock, (3) Jazz & Blues, (4) Flamenco, (5) Opera & Classical, and (6) Author & Melodic Music. These six dimensions are used as indicators of musical taste

in the subsequent Correlational Class Analysis, enabling the identification of different structures of musical preferences.

Sociodemographic

For the analysis of the relationship between symbolic and social boundaries, representative social variables of consumers are explored based on different music genres for each taste structure. To achieve this objective, explanatory variables associated with sociodemographic factors are examined. The following table (table 2) presents the values and distribution of this set of social variables:

Table 2. Variables and categories

Age	n	%
Up to 30	2591	17,8
31 to 40	2188	15,1
41 to 50	2907	20,0
51 to 60	2543	17,5
61 to 70	1983	13,7
more than 71	2312	15,9
Total	**14524**	**100**

Educational level	n	%
Compulsory education	6141	42,3
Post compulsory	4871	33,5
University studies	3512	24,2
Total	**14524**	**100**

Sex	n	%
Male	7096	48,9
Female	7428	51,1
Total	**14524**	**100**

Cultural practices variables indexes

Two variables capturing cultural practices were included: parental cultural practices and respondents' cultural practices during childhood. Both indices were constructed from survey questions measuring the frequency (frequently, occasionally, never) of activities such as reading for leisure, visiting museums or monuments, attending cultural performances, and going to the cinema.

For each set of items, an exploratory factor analysis was conducted (excluding "other cultural activities"), resulting in a single-factor solution in both cases. The Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin statistics indicated adequate sampling (PCPI: KMO = 0.780; CCPI: KMO = 0.756), with explained variance of 65.7% and 61.7%, respectively.

The resulting factor scores were then divided into terciles, producing three levels of cultural practices (low, medium, high) used in the subsequent analyses (see Table 3).

Table 3. Variables and categories

Parental Cultural Practices Index		
Low	4627	31.9
Medium	5072	34.9
High	4825	33.2
Total	**14524**	**100**

Childhood Cultural Practices Index		
Low	4627	31.9
Medium	2916	20.1
High	6981	48.1
Total	**14524**	**100**

Source: author's own elaboration

Results

Four musical taste structures

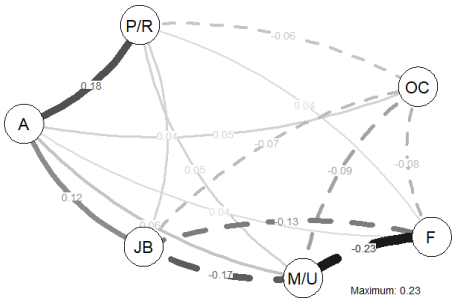
The CCA was conducted using the corclass package in R (Boutyline, 2017), identifying four musical taste structures (MTS), each representing a distinct configuration of associations between musical genres. Below, we describe their main characteristics. The graphical representations display the correlations between genres within each structure. Line width reflects the strength of the association, while dashed lines indicate negative correlations. Non-significant relationships ($p \geq 0.05$) are not shown. Together with the correlation tables, these representations allow us to identify both affinities and oppositions between genres, which can be interpreted as expressions of symbolic–cultural boundaries.

To complement this relational analysis, we examine the mean factor scores of the six musical dimensions within each structure (Table A1 in the Appendix). As the scores are standardized, positive values indicate above-average presence of a dimension and negative values indicate below-average presence. This allows us to characterize the absolute orientation of musical consumption in each structure. In addition, we analyse the distribution of consumers of each original musical genre across the four clusters to assess their relative concentration (see Table A2 in the Appendix).

MTS I (38%): Weak Omnivorism with Symbolic Boundaries

In the first MTS (Figure 1), which represents 38% of respondents, we observe weak positive correlations between several musical genres. Author & Melodic Music shows connections with Pop/Rock and Jazz & Blues, and weaker links with Opera & Classical. These relationships suggest a relatively broad configuration of tastes. However, the structure also reveals clear oppositions, particularly between Modern & Urban Music and several other genres, including Flamenco (–0.232), Jazz & Blues (–0.165) and Opera & Classical (–0.095).

Figure 1. MTS I: Weak Omnivorism with Symbolic Boundaries (n=5526)



	A	P/R	JB	OC	F	M/U
A	1					
P/R	0.178	1				
JB	0.117	0.043	1			
OC	0.046	-0.059	-0.068	1		
F	0.036	0.035	-0.133	-0.076	1	
M/U	0.06	0.046	-0.165	-0.095	-0.232	1

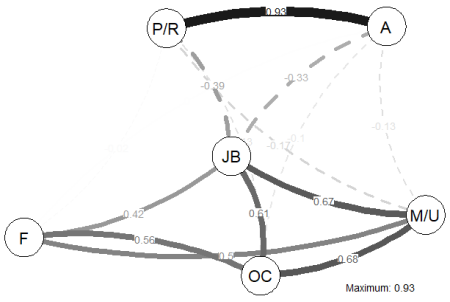
Note: A: Author & Melodic Music; F: Flamenco; JB: Jazz & Blues; M/U: Modern and Urban Music; OC: Opera & Classical; P/R: Pop Rock.

The mean factor scores further clarify the orientation of this structure. Respondents in MTS I show positive scores in several musical dimensions, especially Modern & Urban Music (0.44), Flamenco (0.44), Jazz & Blues (0.28) and Opera & Classical (0.29), while the remaining dimensions remain close to the sample average. This indicates a relatively broad musical orientation that combines several genres rather than concentrating on a single musical genre. These results point to a taste structure characterized by moderate broadening combined with selective exclusions**.** While several musical genres coexist, others remain mutually opposed. In this sense, the structure reflects the presence of symbolic boundaries expressed through the rejection or distancing from certain genres (Merrill et al., 2023; Warde, 2011).

MTS II (25,5%): Low Musical Engagement

The second music taste structure reveals a clear opposition between two sets of musical genres (Figure 2). On one side, a dense cluster of genres shows strong positive correlations among themselves, including Modern and Urban Music, Jazz & Blues, Opera & Classical, and Flamenco. On the other side, two genres, Author & Melodic Music and Pop/Rock, are strongly associated with each other (0.927) but negatively correlated with the rest of the genres in the structure.

Figure 2. MTS II: Low Musical Engagement (n=3698)



	OC	M/U	JB	F	A	P/R
OC	1					
M/U	0.681	1				
JB	0.609	0.667	1			
F	0.557	0.501	0.417	1		
A	-0.098	-0.132	-0.331	0.003	1	
P/R	-0.125	-0.174	-0.394	-0.021	0.927	1

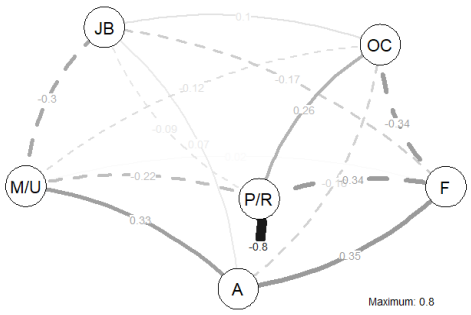
Note: A: Author & Melodic Music; F: Flamenco; JB: Jazz & Blues; M/U: Modern and Urban Music; OC: Opera & Classical; P/R: Pop Rock.

These correlations indicate the presence of a relational opposition between a pair of closely connected genres (Pop/Rock and Author & Melodic Music) and a broader group composed of several other musical genres. This pattern suggests a potential boundary separating more mainstream popular genres from a more heterogeneous set of musical styles. However, the analysis of the mean factor scores provides an important clarification regarding the substantive orientation of this cluster. Respondents belonging to MTS II display negative values across all six musical dimensions, with particularly low values for Pop/Rock (–0.62). This indicates that individuals in this structure tend to report lower-than-average consumption across all musical genres considered in the analysis. These results suggest that this structure is characterized less by a specific configuration of musical tastes than by a generally low level of musical engagement. Rather than reflecting a clearly defined set of genre preferences, this cluster appears to capture respondents whose musical consumption is comparatively limited across the different genres examined.

MTS III (20, 8%): Pop-Dominant Taste Structure

Unlike the previous clusters, the third music taste structure is characterized by a strong opposition between Author & Melodic Music and Pop/Rock (correlation = –0.796) (Figure 3). Each of these genres is connected to different groups of musical styles. Author & Melodic Music shows positive correlations with Flamenco and Modern & Urban Music, while Pop/Rock is weakly associated with Opera & Classical Music.

Figure 3. MTS III: Pop-Dominant Taste Structure (n=3028)



	A	F	M/U	JB	OC	P/R
A	1					
F	0.35	1				
M/U	0.33	0.017	1			
JB	0.073	-0.172	-0.303	1		
OC	-0.155	-0.337	-0.119	0.102	1	
P/R	-0.796	-0.343	-0.224	-0.086	0.263	1

Note: A: Author & Melodic Music; F: Flamenco; JB: Jazz & Blues; M/U: Modern and Urban Music; OC: Opera & Classical; P/R: Pop Rock.

This configuration reveals a relational opposition between two sets of musical genres. On the one hand, Author & Melodic Music is connected to a group of genres typically associated with more popular or traditional styles. On the other hand, Pop/Rock is linked to a different constellation that includes a weak association with Opera & Classical Music. This pattern suggests the existence of a symbolic boundary separating two different configurations of musical preferences. The analysis of the mean factor scores further clarifies the orientation of this cluster. Respondents in MTS III display a

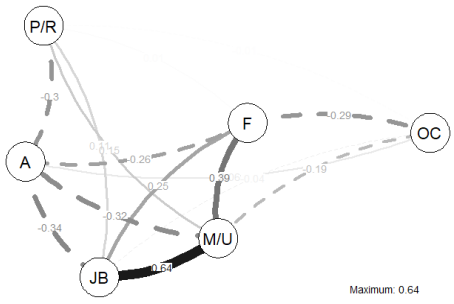
markedly positive score for the Pop/Rock dimension (0.77), while all other musical dimensions remain below the sample average. This indicates that the structure is strongly centred on mainstream popular music, with comparatively limited engagement with other musical genres.

Taken together, these results suggest that this taste structure is organized around a strong preference for pop-rock music, combined with an oppositional relationship with other musical genres, particularly Author & Melodic Music. Rather than reflecting a broad omnivorous orientation, the structure points to a taste configuration dominated by mainstream popular music, where symbolic boundaries are expressed through the rejection of certain alternative genres.

MTS IV (15,6%): Traditional Melodic Orientation

The fourth music taste structure reveals a dense group of positive correlations among Modern & Urban Music, Jazz & Blues, Flamenco and, to a lesser extent, Pop/Rock (Figure 4). In contrast, two genres appear clearly opposed to this interconnected group: Opera & Classical Music and Author & Melodic Music. These negative correlations indicate the presence of a symbolic boundary separating a group of contemporary musical genres from more traditional musical styles.

Figure 4. MTS IV: Traditional Melodic Orientation (n=2272)



	M/U	JB	F	P/R	OC	A
M/U	1					
JB	0.643	1				
F	0.386	0.251	1			
P/R	0.145	0.115	0.007	1		
OC	-0.192	-0.042	-0.294	-0.005	1	
A	-0.32	-0.337	-0.264	-0.297	0.062	1

Note: A: Author & Melodic Music; F: Flamenco; JB: Jazz & Blues; M/U: Modern and Urban Music; OC: Opera & Classical; P/R: Pop Rock.

However, the analysis of the mean factor scores provides a clearer picture of the orientation of this cluster. Respondents belonging to MTS IV display a strongly positive value for the Author & Melodic Music dimension (1.20), while all other musical dimensions remain below the sample average. This indicates that the structure is strongly centred on melodic and traditional musical genres. Taken together, these results suggest that this taste structure reflects a configuration of musical preferences oriented towards more traditional melodic genres, combined with a relative rejection of several contemporary musical styles. In this sense, the symbolic boundary revealed by this cluster opposes traditional melodic music to a broader set of contemporary genres.

These four structures reveal heterogeneous configurations of musical tastes among Spanish consumers, characterized by varying degrees of breadth, specialization and exclusion. Rather than reflecting a single dominant pattern of cultural omnivorousness, the results suggest the coexistence of multiple taste configurations structured by symbolic boundaries between musical genres.

Social characteristics of musical taste structures

Beyond the distribution of consumers across musical genres, it is also relevant to examine the social composition of the different taste structures. Table 4 presents the distribution of several socio-demographic variables and indicators of cultural capital within each structure identified through the CCA. The percentages represent the proportion of individuals belonging to each category within each musical taste structure, which allows comparison between clusters and with the overall distribution of the sample.

The results reveal clear social differences between musical taste structures (Table 4). MTS I shows a higher presence of younger individuals (24.3% aged 30 or younger, compared with 17.8% in the overall sample) and relatively high levels of cultural capital, both in terms of parental cultural practices (38.5%) and respondents' own cultural practices during childhood (53.4%). This social profile is consistent with the relatively broad orientation of musical consumption previously observed in this structure.

Table 4. Social profile of respondents by musical taste structure (%)

Variable	**MTS I**	**MTS II**	**MTS III**	**MTS IV**	**Total**
Women	47.6	53.2	51.8	55.5	**51.1**
Age ≤ 30	24.3	11.1	18.6	12.0	**17.8**
Age ≥ 71	10.5	26.9	7.2	23.0	**15.9**
University education	26.2	18.3	28.3	23.4	**24.2**
High parental cultural practices	38.5	25.4	35.9	29.7	**33.2**
High childhood cultural practices	53.4	41.5	49.1	44.5	**48.1**

In contrast, MTS II is characterized by an older social composition and lower levels of cultural capital. In this cluster, 26.9% of respondents are aged 71 or older, well above the sample average (15.9%). Likewise, only 25.4% report high levels of parental cultural practices and 41.5% report high levels of childhood cultural practices, both clearly below the overall sample. These characteristics are consistent with the generally lower levels of musical consumption identified in this structure.

MTS III presents a different profile, with a relatively high proportion of respondents with university education (28.3%, compared with 24.2% in the total sample) and

moderately high levels of cultural practices. This pattern suggests that a taste structure centred on mainstream popular music may also be associated with relatively high educational attainment.

Finally, MTS IV displays a comparatively older social composition (23% aged 71 or older) and intermediate levels of cultural capital. This profile aligns with the orientation toward more traditional musical genres observed in this cluster, particularly those related to author and melodic music.

These results indicate that musical taste structures not only reflect different orientations of musical consumption but are also embedded in distinct social profiles, particularly with regard to age, educational level and cultural capital.

Symbolic boundaries and social determinants of musical taste structures

While the previous section described the social composition of each musical taste structure, the following analysis examines which social factors are associated with preferences for different musical genres within each cluster. To this end, multiple linear regression models were estimated separately for each CCA structure, allowing us to identify how socio-demographic characteristics and cultural practices are related to musical preferences within each taste configuration (see Tables A3–A6 in the Appendix).

For MTS I, age and educational level emerge as the most relevant predictors. Older respondents and those with higher educational attainment show stronger preferences for genres such as Jazz & Blues and Opera & Classical, while younger individuals tend to be more associated with Modern & Urban Music. These results suggest that the symbolic boundaries observed in this structure are partly structured by generational differences and cultural capital.

In MTS II, the regression models reveal weaker associations between social variables and musical preferences. This finding is consistent with the interpretation of this cluster as a group characterized by generally low levels of musical consumption rather than clearly differentiated taste orientations.

For MTS III, age and educational level again play an important role. Pop/Rock preferences are more strongly associated with younger and more highly educated respondents, whereas preferences for Author & Melodic Music increase with age and are more common among individuals with lower levels of parental cultural practices. This pattern reinforces the boundary identified between different configurations of popular musical tastes.

Finally, in MTS IV, age and gender appear as the most influential variables. Younger respondents are more strongly associated with contemporary genres such as Modern &

Urban Music and Jazz, while older individuals tend to prefer Author & Melodic Music. Gender differences are also observed, with men showing a stronger association with contemporary genres and women displaying higher preferences for melodic music. These results suggest that generational and gender differences contribute to structuring the symbolic boundary between contemporary and traditional musical tastes.

Discussion and conclusions

In this study, we aimed to contribute to the debate on cultural consumption and the implications of musical tastes for the theory of cultural omnivorousness. Using data on musical preferences in Spain, we examined the relational structure of tastes and the extent to which contemporary patterns of musical consumption reflect the persistence or transformation of symbolic cultural boundaries. To do so, we identified different configurations of musical taste structures and analysed both positive and negative correlations between musical genres, capturing not only affinities but also oppositions between tastes.

Following recent contributions emphasizing the role of dislikes and aversions in cultural consumption (Jarness, 2015; Merrill et al., 2023; Nault et al., 2021; Warde, 2011), our analysis considers both preferences and rejections. In this sense, the use of Correlational Class Analysis (Boutyline, 2017; Goldberg, 2011) allowed us to identify relational patterns of musical tastes and to uncover how symbolic boundaries are structured through oppositions between genres.

Our findings reveal a clear diversity of musical taste structures among Spanish consumers, confirming previous research on heterogeneous patterns of cultural consumption in Spain (Ariño & Llopis-Goig, 2017, 2021; Herrera-Usagre, 2011, 2013). However, the results do not support the idea that cultural omnivorousness constitutes a dominant pattern. Instead, we identify distinct configurations characterized by varying degrees of breadth, specialization and exclusion.

Across all four taste structures, symbolic boundaries emerge through oppositions between musical genres. Even in the most internally diverse structure (MTS I), preferences coexist with selective exclusions. These findings therefore provide limited support for strong versions of the omnivorousness thesis and are more consistent with approaches emphasizing the persistence of boundaries and the structuring role of dislikes (Atkinson, 2011; de Vries & Reeves, 2022; Leguina et al., 2016; Nault et al., 2021). In this sense, the coexistence of relatively broad repertoires with selective exclusions suggests that openness to diverse musical genres does not necessarily imply the disappearance of hierarchical distinctions. Rather, it may coexist with more subtle forms of differentiation, including selective distancing and even condescension toward certain popular musical genres, thereby expressing what has been described as a form of "flexible superiority" (Prieur, Savage, & Flemmen, 2023).

At the same time, we identify several univorous taste configurations, some associated with more traditional and legitimate genres, and others centred on contemporary popular genres such as pop and rock. This supports the idea that symbolic boundaries do not operate solely along high–low distinctions but also through oppositions between traditional and contemporary musical forms (Bellavance, 2008). In addition, one structure reflects generally low engagement with music, consistent with previous findings on culturally inactive consumers (Chan & Goldthorpe, 2007).

The analysis also highlights the role of social factors in shaping taste structures. Age, educational level and cultural practices during childhood emerge as key variables. Age appears as a central structuring factor: younger consumers tend to prefer contemporary and popular genres and to reject more traditional forms, while broader patterns of consumption are more likely when higher education and stronger cultural practices during childhood are present. This combination is particularly visible in the largest structure, which can be described as a form of weak omnivorousness characterized by relative breadth alongside clear exclusions (de Vries & Reeves, 2022). Our data do not allow us to distinguish active rejection from indifference or lack of familiarity (Warde, 2011). Thus, the analysis identifies relational patterns of symbolic exclusion, but not the specific motivations underlying them.

Importantly, our findings also show that individuals with relatively high cultural capital may develop univorous taste structures centred on contemporary popular genres. This partly challenges earlier formulations of the omnivorousness thesis, which associated restricted tastes with lower education (Peterson, 2005). In our data, the interaction between age and education produces configurations in which younger and more educated consumers display relatively narrow preferences oriented toward genres such as pop and rock, in line with research highlighting the role of new aesthetic criteria such as authenticity or originality (Hahl, Zuckerman, & Kim, 2017; Prieur, Rosenlund, & Skjott-Larsen, 2008).

Cultural practices during childhood also contribute to shaping musical consumption. Higher levels of such practices are associated with broader patterns of consumption, but do not eliminate exclusions between genres. This finding reinforces the continued relevance of social origin and cultural capital in structuring cultural tastes (Lizardo, 2018; Nault et al., 2021).

In this sense, our results indicate that symbolic and cultural boundaries remain central in musical consumption. Rather than disappearing, these boundaries appear increasingly fragmented and multidimensional, organized around different combinations of breadth, legitimacy and exclusion. Cultural distinction thus operates through a variety of mechanisms that extend beyond traditional forms of elitism, involving generational dynamics, cultural capital and alternative evaluative criteria (de Vries & Reeves, 2022; Lizardo, 2018; Peters, van Eijck, & Michael, 2018).

Finally, some limitations should be acknowledged. The survey data do not allow distinctions between artists within genres, which may obscure important internal variation, particularly in broad categories such as pop or rock (Nault et al., 2021). It should be acknowledged that contemporary musical consumption is increasingly mediated by the algorithms of digital platforms, which promote forms of access and music discovery that do not always coincide with traditional genres. Thus, symbolic boundaries would also be partly shaped by these algorithmic recommendation logics (Fernández Rodríguez & Heikkilä, 2025; Prior, 2018). Moreover, the quantitative design does not capture the meanings and discourses underlying preferences and rejections. Future research combining relational quantitative approaches with qualitative methods would therefore be valuable to better understand the symbolic logics of musical taste.

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